

UNIT 4 · LESSON 1

Systemic Grace

50-55 min · March Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students extend the concept of grace from the interpersonal to the institutional and systemic — identifying how grace operates at the level of communities, organizations, and structures — and articulate one specific systemic grace contribution they are positioned to make.
DURATION	50-55 min · March Week 1
KEY VOCABULARY	systemic grace · structural injustice · institutional repair · collective accountability · grace at scale · reform vs. transformation
OPENING REVIEW	'Unit 3 ended with the Graduation of the Heart. Unit 4 begins today. The question changes one final time: not what do I do with the people who hurt me, not who am I becoming — but what will I build? Today: grace at scale.'

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES 11–12 · LATE HIGH SCHOOL

Goal 3 — Responsible Decision-Making**3A.5a** Apply ethical reasoning to evaluate societal practices.**3C.5b** Work cooperatively with others to plan, implement, and evaluate a project that addresses an identified need in the broader community.*Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).***ANCHOR CHART**

SYSTEMIC GRACE PERSONAL GRACE: A deliberate extension of goodwill to one person. (Books 4-5)

COMMUNITY GRACE: A culture where goodwill is the default assumption. (Book 4, Unit 4)

SYSTEMIC GRACE: Grace built into the structures, policies, and practices of institutions. Where repair is expected. Where accountability is restorative, not punitive. Where the most vulnerable members are protected by design, not by charity. SYSTEMIC GRACE IS NOT: Ignoring structural harm and calling it forgiveness · Excusing institutional failure in the name of compassion ·

Performing grace while structural injustice continues. SYSTEMIC GRACE IS: Accountability structures that produce repair, not just punishment · Policies that extend the same goodwill to all

members as default · Institutions whose operational values match their stated ones · The person who knows what the institution is supposed to be — and holds it accountable to that. POST: Before class. KEEP: Unit 4.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · BOOK 5 · THE CAPSTONE (11–12)

Systemic Grace

Unit 4

GRACE

PERSONAL GRACE

- A deliberate extension of goodwill to one person

COMMUNITY GRACE

- A culture where goodwill is the default assumption

SYSTEMIC GRACE

- Grace built into structures, policies, and practices
- Repair is expected
- Accountability is restorative
- The vulnerable protected by design

Systemic grace is not excusing structural harm in the name of compassion.

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OPENING RITUAL

90 seconds 'Both feet on the floor. One breath slower than usual.' [Pause 15 seconds.] 'Unit 4 begins today. This is the final unit of Book 5 — and of the entire Architecture of Grace curriculum. Everything that was built in Books 1 through 5 leads here. Not to a conclusion — to a beginning. What will you build with everything you have been given?' [Post: 'What will the world be like because you were in it — and what are you willing to do to build that world?']

► DIRECT INSTRUCTION

Scripted teaching sequence · scripted sequence · follow the steps · read aloud or in your own words

NOTE

STEP 1 8 min FROM PERSONAL TO SYSTEMIC — THE PROGRESSION 'You have been practicing grace for two years. Personal grace: one deliberate act of goodwill toward one person. Community grace: a culture where goodwill is the default assumption. Today: systemic grace. Grace built into the structures, policies, and practices of institutions.' [Pause.] 'The difference is permanence. Personal grace is available when you are present. Systemic grace continues when you are not. It lives in the structure — in who is included in decision-making, in what the accountability system protects, in what the institution rewards by design.' Ask: 'Name one institution that you believe practices systemic grace — and one that does not. What is the structural difference?' Take 3-4 responses. STEP 2 10 min WHAT SYSTEMIC GRACE REQUIRES OF THE INDIVIDUAL 'Here is the challenge: it requires the willingness to name structural harm — even when the structure benefits you.' Write on board: SYSTEMIC GRACE = personal goodwill + structural accountability + willingness to name harm even when it is inconvenient. 'Fatima enters her university and discovers that its stated commitment to diversity is not reflected in its operational reality. She has two options: adapt and benefit from the existing structure, or name the gap and work toward closing it. Systemic grace is the second option.' Students write: 'One institution I am entering where systemic grace is needed — and the specific gap between stated and operational values that I am positioned to name.' STEP 3 10 min THE SYSTEMIC GRACE CONTRIBUTION — WHAT IS YOURS? 'At 17 or 18, you cannot restructure the institution. But you can be the person who names the gap. You can be the person who builds the coalition. You can be the person who does not adapt silently when adaptation means normalizing structural harm.' [Pause.] 'Your systemic grace contribution is not defined by your position. It is defined by your willingness to consistently hold the institution accountable to its stated values — from whatever position you occupy.' Students write: 'The specific systemic grace contribution I am positioned to make is _____. The cost of making it is _____. What holds me in place when the cost is real is _____.'

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During Step 2, a student who insists systemic change is impossible — who describes structural reform as naive.

MAY SIGNAL This student may have direct personal experience of systemic failure. Their skepticism may be entirely earned.

ACTION Do not challenge the skepticism directly. After class: 'The cynicism you brought today — it sounds like it came from somewhere real. I would like to understand what you are actually describing.' The invitation to systemic grace does not require optimism. It requires willingness to name what is wrong. Even that is enough. | | --- |

NOTE

Prior AoG (Book 4 Foundation) Grades 11-12 (Capstone) The Community Grace Audit examined grace at the peer-community level — what one person's consistent practice produces in their immediate environment. The leverage point was personal and proximate. Systemic grace extends the lens to institutions and structures. The student is not just a person in the room — they are a future designer of rooms. The choices they make about what to build, what to name, and what to refuse to normalize are systemic choices.

EXIT TICKET

"Systemic grace differs from personal grace because _____. The institution I am entering where systemic grace is needed is _____. The specific gap I am positioned to name is _____. My systemic grace contribution — from whatever position I occupy — is _____." Journal — private. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Unit 4 opens with the most expansive lens in the curriculum. The most important teaching move: resist both naive optimism and defeating cynicism. Systemic grace is not the belief that institutions will change easily. It is the commitment to naming what is wrong and working toward what is right — from whatever position you occupy, for as long as it takes. Students who carry direct experience of systemic injustice need this frame to be honored, not bypassed. Their experience is not an argument against systemic grace — it is the argument for it.

FAMILY CONNECTION · CONVERSATION STARTER

Today students began Unit 4 — The Orchard Legacy, the final unit of Architecture of Grace. The question of the unit: what will the world be like because you were in it? Conversation-starter: 'Is

there an institution — a school, a workplace, a community, a government — where you think the gap between what it says it stands for and how it actually operates is worth naming? What would naming it look like?’

SCENARIO CARDS

Print and laminate before unit. Two cards per lesson.

B 5 - 2 2 A SYSTEMIC GRACE

THE SITUATION

In her first job, Fatima designs an onboarding process for new employees — something she wished had existed when she arrived. The process includes one thing no formal onboarding had ever given her: a genuine welcome. Not a checklist, not a login credential, but a person who was assigned to introduce her and check in during the first month. The people she onboards stay longer. They say the welcome was what made the difference.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

What does Fatima build that is different from what she received — and where did she find the idea? Fatima turns a personal experience of a Grace Gap into a systemic change. What does that transformation require? A 'genuine welcome' is described as the differentiating factor. Why does something that seems simple carry that much weight? Design one systemic change in an environment you are currently in or are entering — one that extends grace structurally rather than individually.

SYSTEMIC GRACE *Systemic grace is grace built into the structure of an environment — the way the organization works, rather than the individual goodwill of its members. It is more durable than individual acts of grace because it does not depend on any single person's good day. Fatima didn't just be welcoming — she built a welcoming system. The difference is scalable and sustainable.*

B 5 - 2 2 B SYSTEMIC GRACE

THE SITUATION

When Marcus evaluates the team culture he has observed in high-performing organizations, he notices a pattern: the teams that function best have systems for acknowledging each other's

contributions — not only from leaders downward, but laterally and upward. Nobody is too senior to be thanked for their work. The acknowledgment is not performance. It is structural: built into how meetings are run and how progress is communicated.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

What is the systemic element Marcus is identifying — and why does its structural nature matter? Grace that is structural is more reliable than grace that depends on individual mood or memory. Why? Marcus is about to enter a new team environment. What one structural practice could he advocate for or model — without requiring institutional permission? Design the environment you want to build in your next chapter: what grace-shaped structures would it contain?

BUILDING THE ENVIRONMENT *The environments you enter will already have cultures. Some will align with your values. Some will not. The question is not only how you navigate the culture you find — but what culture you begin to build, even in small ways, from the moment you arrive. Marcus's observation is an early vision. The lesson asks you to take it further: what kind of environment will you actively build?*

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

This is a free preview.

Sample Lesson · Book 5 · The Capstone (11–12)

The complete, classroom-ready curriculum — with anchor charts, worksheets, Illinois SEL alignment, and scripted Direct Instruction — is part of the Architecture of Grace district library. Educators can license the full set; families can find materials in the family store.

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